

Inside EDGE

Behind the bright lights and feelgood fanaticism, South African cricket runs into the IPL's less attractive side

| By Neil Manthorp in Cape Town |

The IPL's ability to reorganise and relocate to South Africa inside 30 days was, and will always remain, one of the most spectacular pieces of sports logistics ever contemplated, let alone achieved. And, much as the endless back-slapping and self-congratulation began to wear thin, it was certainly merited in the early days.

South Africans, virtually without exception, became barrel-chested with pride at the prospect of the tournament moving to the country and stopped at nothing to make it feasible. Some, like Cricket South Africa (CSA) Chief Executive Gerald Majola, were aware of the potential long-term benefits and prepared to sacrifice just about anything, but others were simply and naively unaware of what was about to hit them.

Majola did what he was told to do right from the start. He refused to comment on speculation and publicly denied any contact with Lalit Modi just 24 hours after hosting a conference call with six South African franchise chief executives to canvass opinion about the possibility of staging the tournament. As one South African franchise executive member put it, "India runs the world of cricket now, so best not to upset the beast," he said.

The South African cricket fraternity is very good at doing exactly that—"cricket". Sacrifices have been

made for generations, across all cultural divides, to keep the game alive.

What they have never experienced before is being 'used', certainly not in the way the IPL have used them. The Rajasthan Royals, as one example amongst dozens, formed a "strategic alliance" with the Cape Cobras in Cape Town and asked for an office at Newlands for the fortnight before the tournament and then its duration. Within days, the IPL franchise had spread like bacteria in a petri-dish



THE OPENING EUPHORIA HAS GIVEN WAY TO A DEEPENING CULTURAL DIVIDE



SOUTH AFRICA'S IPL has featured bags of R480,000 in cash, gold limos and an 'education budget' equal to the cost of the launch party

leaving local staff without a desk, literally. One infuriated employee found himself evicted from his office without notice, apology or explanation after arriving at work. "There seems to be a 'right of entitlement' that exists amongst these IPL people. Give them a finger and they bite your arm off," he said.

A senior coach at the Cobras, having been compromised on everything from players, to nets and the cost of practice balls, was then asked to assemble his strongest team for a televised warm-up match without

payment for his players: "They want everything for nothing. Our franchise is getting R1 million (\$111,510) for being a host venue. That is not a lot of money however you spread it," he said.

His lack of understanding stems from what the core of the IPL is all about: money and ego. He has never had money and his employer, despite being regarded as the "glamour" franchise in South Africa, is the poorest of them all. Perhaps it's simple jealousy, but the flaunting of wealth has been genuinely unpleasant at times.

The opening party at a lavish ho-